

AHMEDABAD | The Hard Way

Narendra Modi is on a collision course with the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre over the Gujarat Control of Organised Crime (GUJCOC) Bill. Last week, the Centre refused to clear the Bill and asked the state Government to amend the provision that makes the confession of an accused before the police admissible as evidence in court. The Centre claims that the provision is against its manifesto under which it had scrapped POTA in the past and that it is often misused by the police to provide quick results.

Modi argues that the Bill is a replica of a law that is already in force in Maharashtra. According to Modi, if the amendments are incorporated, the Bill will lose its teeth. "If we are to give a befitting reply to terrorism, a tough anti-terror law is a must. Most developed countries



BHASKAR PAUL

MODI WANTS A TOUGH ANTI-TERROR LAW IN GUJARAT

have tougher laws to combat terrorism. Why can't all Indian political parties have a uniform policy to fight terrorism?" asks Modi. POTA may be dead and buried, but its replicas won't go away easily.

by Uday Mahurkar

Free Ride

Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel seems to be taking the national carrier's financial woes to heart. He recently hitched a free ride on steel magnate Lakshmi Mittal's personal helicopter to shuttle between London and Paris instead of flying Air India.

CHANDIGARH | Sad Strife

It doesn't pay to be dishonest, as Major (ret'd) Gurjinder Benipal discovered. Benipal, a sub-registrar in Ludhiana, was stripped, dragged out of his office and thrashed by alleged supporters of local Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) councillor Kanwaljit Singh Karwal. The two have



RAJESH BHAMBRI

been at loggerheads since November 2008 when Benipal refused to let Karwal inaugurate the office. "Karwal would come to me for illegal and unfair favours which I refused," says Benipal. Matters turned uglier when Benipal blew the lid off a multi-crore fake stamp scam: xerox copies of registration stamps were being passed off as originals. Karwal stormed his office with 50 men. They snatched Benipal's licenced revolver, shot at him and beat him up. "I have paid the price for being honest," says the former major.

by Arvind Chhabra

KERALA | Poles Apart

The CPI(M) is going all out to appease the Catholic Church. During the polls, the Church had led a concerted campaign against the "atheist and anti-minority Commies". Its main grouse was the LDF's attempts to regulate the Christian-dominated private education sector. Politburo member and Home Minister Kodayeri Balakrishnan, Education Minister M.A. Baby and Health Minister P.K. Sreemathi rushed to the residence of Catholicos Moran Mor Baselios Cleemis, the Thiruvananthapuram Archbishop, to greet him on his 50th birthday. The archbishop said, "Creative attempts have been opened to clear differences between the Church and the Government." Hardcore Marxists, however, see this as a shameless capitulation. "The Church and the communists can never come together. Both are poles apart on matters of faith and God which are essential for us," said Fr Stephen Alathara, a spokesperson for the Church. by M. G. Radhakrishnan



BABY (RIGHT) WITH THE ARCHBISHOP